

among the company's top short-haul international destinations and has entered the overall Top 10. According to him, Vietnam's multi-airport connectivity to Hanoi, Ho Chi Minh City, and Da Nang has opened the country to travellers across metros, while its food, experiences, culture, beaches, cuisine and vibrant cities have made it especially appealing to younger, experience-seeking Indians.

That younger traveller is visible across Hanoi, phone in hand, chasing the images that have made the city famous online. Train Street is the clearest example. Tourists sit in cafés along a narrow railway track, waiting for a train to pass between them. There is nothing especially ornate about the train itself. It is not a heritage steam train like the Darjeeling Himalayan Railway or the Nilgiri Mountain Railway. Yet, in the age of Instagram, it has become a ritual, and for many visitors, a non-negotiable stop.

But Hanoi is more than its 'viral' corners. At the centre of the city lies Hoan Kiem Lake, a pocket of calm beside the energy of the Old Quarter. Joggers circle its edges in the morning and elderly residents exercise under the trees. The lake has its own legend involving a magical sword, a courageous emperor, a Dragon King, and the Golden Turtle God, Kim Qui.

The city's more formal historical memory is visible at the Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum, where Vietnam's revolutionary leader, still affectionately called Uncle Ho, is remembered with reverence. He did not live to see the country's final unification in 1975, but his role in Vietnam's struggle for independence remains central to the national

**1. A view of Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum**

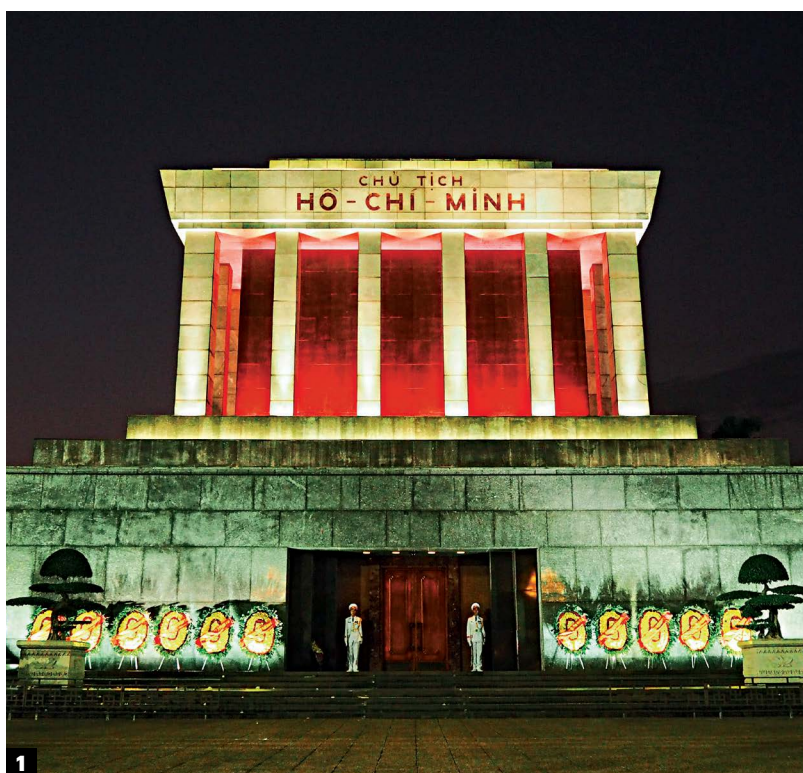
**2. Egg coffee is a must-have: egg yolks whipped with sugar and condensed milk into a creamy foam layered over strong black coffee**

**3. Train Street is a place where tourists sit in cafés along a**

**narrow railway track, waiting for a train to pass**

**4. Founded more than 1,000 years ago, Hanoi is one of Southeast Asia's oldest capitals**

**5. Hanoi's street food remains spectacular, and no visit feels complete without *bun cha***



imagination. Other traces of that turbulent past survive at Hoa Lo Prison, associated with French colonial rule, and at the Sofitel Legend Metropole Hanoi, which once served as a wartime shelter.

The Metropole also signals another Hanoi: one of luxury, heritage hospitality, and old-world glamour. Its elegant Angelina bar is a lovely place to spend an evening over cocktails, watching the city's well-dressed locals. The hotel is frequently sold out, which



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